ic of autotune and a top production/ songwriting team, a former Miss World and Bollywood star could become the Indian Shakira, opening up a whole new market for Indian music. Her first two singles—the anodyne 'In My City' and the hopelessly tone-deaf 'Exotic'—featured American stars will.i.am and Pitbull, respectively, and were backed by a gargantuan marketing push.

That first attempt didn't work, but, since then, the music industry landscape has changed. The internet, and recent cloud-based technologies that facilitate online collaboration, have significantly lowered the barriers for an artist to work with someone across the globe. Streaming has also lowered the curtain on the idea of genres as silos: fans no longer expect artists to stick to a particular sound and celebrate unique innovation instead.

But the biggest change—one that has been accelerated by the pandemic—is the increasing dependence on social media and digital reach as a measure of success. With each big pop star having a captive audience of millions of followers, it has never been easier to cross-market, and fandom-driven engagement is relatively independent of the actual quality of the collaboration. The '1+1=3' formula of cross-marketing has never been easier to implement.

The approach does have its pitfalls, though. Some of these collabs are so obviously dreamed up in a boardroom that it taints the thrill of discovering a new artist and poring over their catalogue. Quality also suffers when the bigger artist does the collab as a favour, phoning it in or sending in an old verse—making the track into a collage rather than a real collab. But the biggest problem is that the international collab is no magic pill—it cannot solve the basic problem of a domestic music industry that is risk-averse and does not award innovation. It isn't language or the lack of a big brand feature that's kept Indian artists from becoming global stars—the problems run far deeper, starting with a serious lack of investment in finding and developing innovative Indian talent. Until that happens—bar an isolated success or two—no number of big-name collaborators can put India on the path of Latin-pop or K-pop. All this hype, it's no more than lipstick on a pig. ■

– Bhanuj Kappal



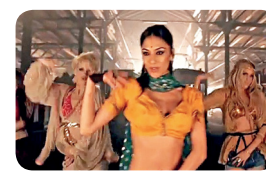
STRIKING A CHORD

When India partnered with the world



Akon, Hamsika Iyer – *'Chammak Challo'*
The centre-piece of composer duo Vishal-Shekhar's soundtrack for the 2011 SRK-starrer *Ra.One* was 'Chammak Challo', written in collaboration with Senegalese-American superstar Akon, who sang on the track alongside Hamsika Iyer. It's rumoured that Akon was paid a cool Rs 2.5 crore.

Skyhabor ft. Dan Tomkins and Marty Friedman – *'Catharsis'*
This song off the Indian band's 2012 debut album proved that we could compete—and collaborate—with the best. Ex-Megadeth shredder Marty Friedman plays a sublime guest solo, featuring vocals by Tesseract (and future Skyharbor) frontman Daniel Tompkins.



A.R. Rahman and Pussycat Dolls – *'Jai Ho (You Are My Destiny)'*
Rahman has an illustrious and growing list of international collaborations, but having reached #15 on the Billboard Top 100 chart, this English remake of his *Slumdog Millionaire* hit stands out.

Enrique Iglesias ft. Sunidhi Chauhan – *'Heartbeat (India Mix)'*
After *Escape*, Enrique's fanbase in India was so strong that he released an India edition of his 2010 album *Euphoria*, featuring this rework with Sunidhi Chauhan that added an Indian folk touch to it.





Nas and Divine, Ranveer Singh – *'NY se Mumbai'*
Off the *Gully Boy* soundtrack, this collaboration between Divine, film lead Ranveer Singh and American rap icon Nas (also the film's executive co-producer) heralded the arrival of Indian rap on the world stage.